

# LESSONS TO BE LEARNED DURING A STORM

**INTRO:** (Talk about storms we can see coming and sudden storms – Talk about how there is very little preparation for sudden storms)

(When we can see a storm coming we stock up on water, bread, milk, chips, honey buns, twinkies etc... What is it about storms that cause us to crave things we would normally not eat?)

Texas has been battered by hurricane Harvey for the last couple of days, and may still have two or three days of devastation to come. Storms are:

- Predictable... They will occur!
- Unpredictable... Storms make liars of weathermen. They have a mind of their own!

The entire 27<sup>th</sup> chapter of the book of Acts is dedicated to a storm encountered by the Apostle Paul. In this chapter Paul, along with many other prisoners, were being transported via ship, from Jerusalem to Rome. (2,130 miles – 3 hours flight – They were months at sea)

Acts 27:10 Paul warns the shipmasters that they should not sail from Crete and that if they did they could lose the ship and the lives of all who sailed with them. Because Crete was not a pleasant place to spend the winter the crew decided to ignore Paul's warning!

If you leave an unpleasant place prematurely you very well may be setting yourself up for a rough ride! God has planned our lives through pleasant places – There is unpleasant territory between pleasant places!

In verse 14 the storm is described as Euroclydon (Euro-clyde-on) and is the equivalent of a hurricane on the Mediterranean.

This storm went on for days and beat the ship, the crew, and the passengers to a breaking point. Storms have a way of doing this.

## **GOD SPEAKS THROUGH THE STORM...**

If we listen closely enough, God speaks THROUGH our storms.

The storm Paul encountered had become so severe that the crew and passengers started throwing everything overboard that wasn't absolutely necessary! It was then that God spoke THROUGH Paul. Acts 27:21-26 (NKJV) *“But after long abstinence from food, then Paul stood in the midst of them*

*and said, “Men, you should have listened to me, and not have sailed from Crete and incurred this disaster and loss. 22 And now I urge you to take heart, for there will be no loss of life among you, but only of the ship. 23 For there stood by me this night an angel of the God to whom I belong and whom I serve, 24 saying, ‘Do not be afraid, Paul; you must be brought before Caesar; and indeed God has granted you all those who sail with you.’ 25 Therefore take heart, men, for I believe God that it will be just as it was told me. 26 However, we must run aground on a certain island.”*

There are things God wants to say to us that can only be heard THROUGH a storm!

## **GOD SPEAKS IN THE STORM**

When we are encountering the worst of the storm we should be silent so that we can hear what God wants to say **IN** the storm!

Acts 27:30-32 (NKJV) *“As the sailors were seeking to escape from the ship, when they had let down the skiff into the sea, under pretense of putting out anchors from the prow, 31 Paul said to the centurion and the soldiers, “Unless these men stay in the ship, you cannot be saved.” 32 Then the soldiers cut away the ropes of the skiff and let it fall off.”*

- The motion of the storm was so severe that neither the crew nor passengers had been able to eat in fourteen days! (Sometimes the storm becomes so severe that the things we love the most are no longer attractive to us)
- The crew was pretending to let down anchors but they were really letting down life rafts so they could escape and abandon the passengers! (Storm weary people tend to attempt a premature escape to their own hurt – Stay IN the storm so you can hear what God has to

say IN the storm! - God has never abandoned anyone!)

At this point God speaks through Paul IN the storm! The advice of Paul is great advice to all of us when we are IN a storm! Listen to what he says:

- If you decide to abandon the ship for a lifeboat you will perish... Stay IN the ship! Don't let the storm chase you out of the safety of the ship!
- If you will stay IN the ship, you will be saved... The ship is not a guarantee against storms; it is a guarantee against loss!

## **GOD SPEAKS FROM THE STORM**

The storm drove the ship, crew, and passengers into the Island of Malta. If you stay with the ship you will emerge FROM the storm humbly, holy, and healthy!

Paul, the crew, and the passengers emerged FROM the ship alive!

- Life emerges FROM the storm... Paul and his traveling companions were saved FROM the storm!
- New relationships come FROM the storm... Paul and his compares' learned to respect one another and became acquainted with the people of Malta! Think of all the relationships that have been forged in your life FROM a storm!
- Miracles come FROM the storm... Paul was bitten by a snake – He shook it off in the fire!
- Our circles of influence are impacted FROM the storm... The barbarians, the crew, and fellow passengers turned to God because of the storm! Your storm will cause you to learn to trust God in a new way! Those around you will never see God in the same light because of your storm!

## **CONCLUSION:**

- Bright sunshine follows the storm...
- The dust is settled by the storm...
- New things follow the storm...